Proposal for Emoji: Kidney

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David Rhew source: World Medical Innovation Forum profile
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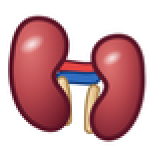
Identification

Suggested name: Kidney
Suggested keywords: renal; anatomy; organ; filtration; urine; hydration; dialysis; transplant; donation; stone; bean-shaped
Suggested category: People & Body - body-parts
Suggested sort location: Near anatomical heart, lungs, and brain in the body-parts subgroup.

Required Example Images

Size	Color	Black and white
18x18		
72x72		

The paradigm shows two asymmetrical kidneys with their medial hila facing inward, a short central vascular junction, and two short ureter cues. The paired presentation restores the organ's familiar anatomical identity while removing the full vascular tower and thin textbook detail that fail at emoji size. The right kidney sits slightly lower, helping distinguish the silhouette from lungs and other symmetric paired forms. Vendors may simplify shading and plumbing detail while preserving two inward-facing kidney forms and their vertical offset.

I, Shuhan He, certify that these example images are original work created for this proposal, that I own all IP Rights in them, and that they contain no third-party artwork, logo, trademark, or text. I release the images under the CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication and grant the rights required by the Unicode Emoji Proposal Agreement and License.

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Factors for Inclusion

A. Multiple meanings

Kidney has established meanings beyond a literal anatomical reference. Merriam-Webster defines a kidney bean as an edible, usually kidney-shaped seed and defines kidney-shaped as shaped like a kidney. These are established food and shape meanings rather than a pun or temporary campaign.

Sources: Merriam-Webster: kidney bean and Merriam-Webster: kidney-shaped.

B. Use in sequences

Kidney can combine with existing emoji to create messages without standardized sequences:

- Kidney + droplet: filtration, fluid balance, or urine production.
- Kidney + hospital or pill: kidney care, dialysis, transplant follow-up, or medication review.
- Kidney + people or heart: living donation, transplant, recipient, or support.
- Kidney + test tube or microscope: blood and urine tests, imaging, or biopsy.

NIDDK documents filtration, fluid balance, urine production, dialysis, transplantation, and medication review in kidney care: Your Kidneys & How They Work and Choosing a Treatment for Kidney Failure. MedlinePlus lists blood, urine, imaging, and biopsy tests for kidneys: Kidney Tests.

C. Breaks new ground

Yes. The current Unicode Emoji List has no kidney or urinary-system organ. Beans primarily represent food; a droplet cannot identify the organ that filters blood and produces urine; and hospital, pill, and syringe represent care or interventions rather than the kidney itself. Kidney would therefore add a distinct internal-organ concept and enable messages that cannot be expressed clearly with existing emoji.

D. Distinctiveness

The two maroon organ bodies, inward-facing hila, short red-and-blue vascular junction, and downward tan ureters make the proposed paradigm visually distinct from the existing beans emoji. Beans are presented as separate food items without an anatomical relationship or plumbing. The purpose-built 18x18 versions preserve the paired silhouette, vertical offset, and central anatomical cue in color and black-and-white.

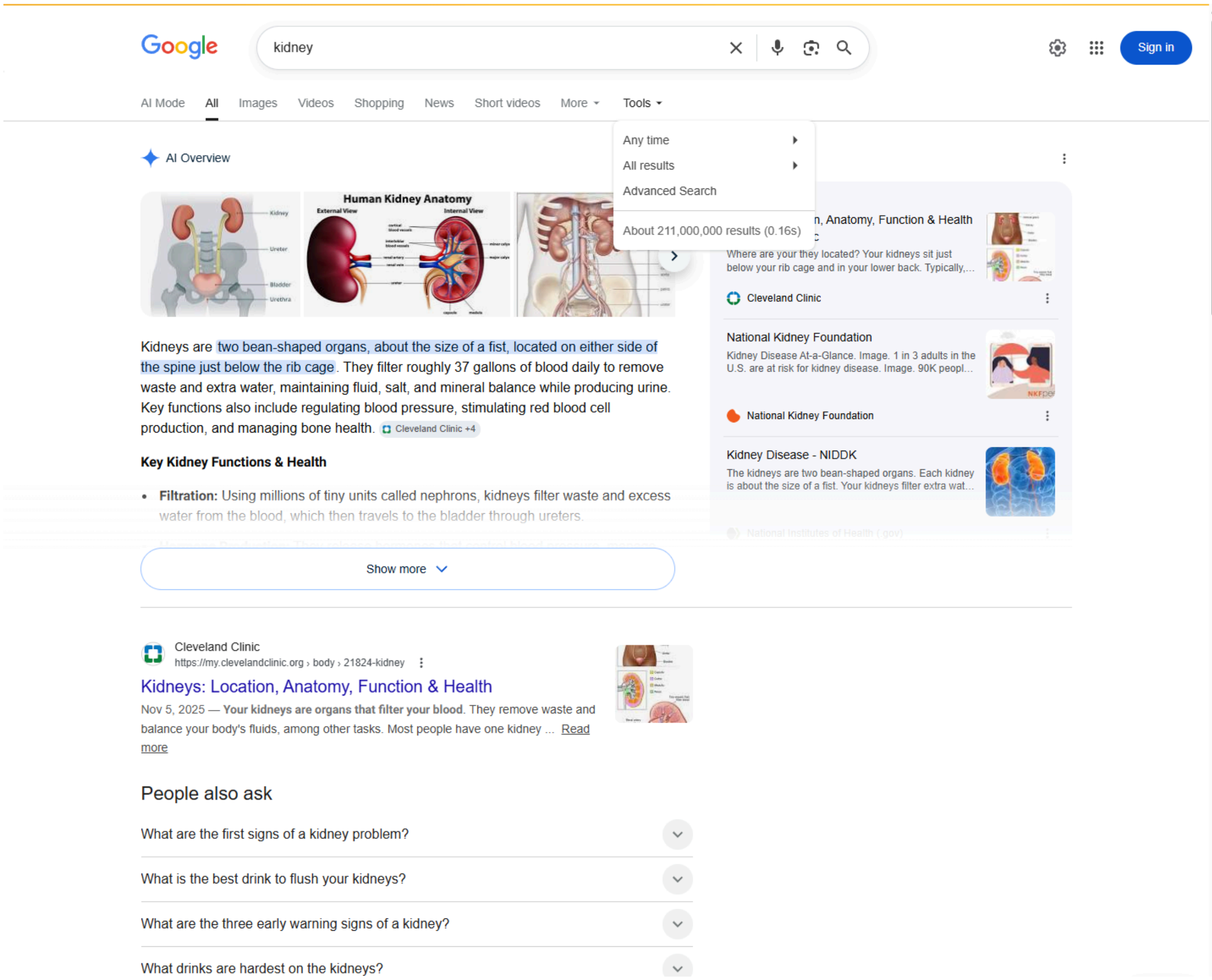
Deterministic computer validation checks exact dimensions, true black-and-white palette, foreground connectedness, and normalized silhouette distance from Beans, Droplet, Anatomical Heart, Lungs, Balloon, and Light Bulb using pinned Noto Emoji assets. The required assets pass the dimension, palette, and connectedness checks. The color 18x18 silhouette currently records an intersection-over-union of 0.750 with Lungs against the prerelease ceiling of 0.72, while its 64-bit difference-hash distance of 23 passes the floor of 16. This one open geometric gate is recorded rather than hidden; it does not establish semantic confusion, and a semantic computer comparison remains required before canonical promotion. Reproducible validation report.

E. Expected usage level

The term kidney spans anatomy and physiology, urine production and fluid balance, kidney tests, dialysis, transplantation, living donation, and medication review. These uses are documented by NIDDK's kidney-function overview, NIDDK's kidney-failure treatment guide, NIDDK's transplant guide, and MedlinePlus Kidney Tests. The five frequency screenshots required by Unicode are embedded below; Google Trends and Google Books compare kidney with Unicode's reference term elephant.

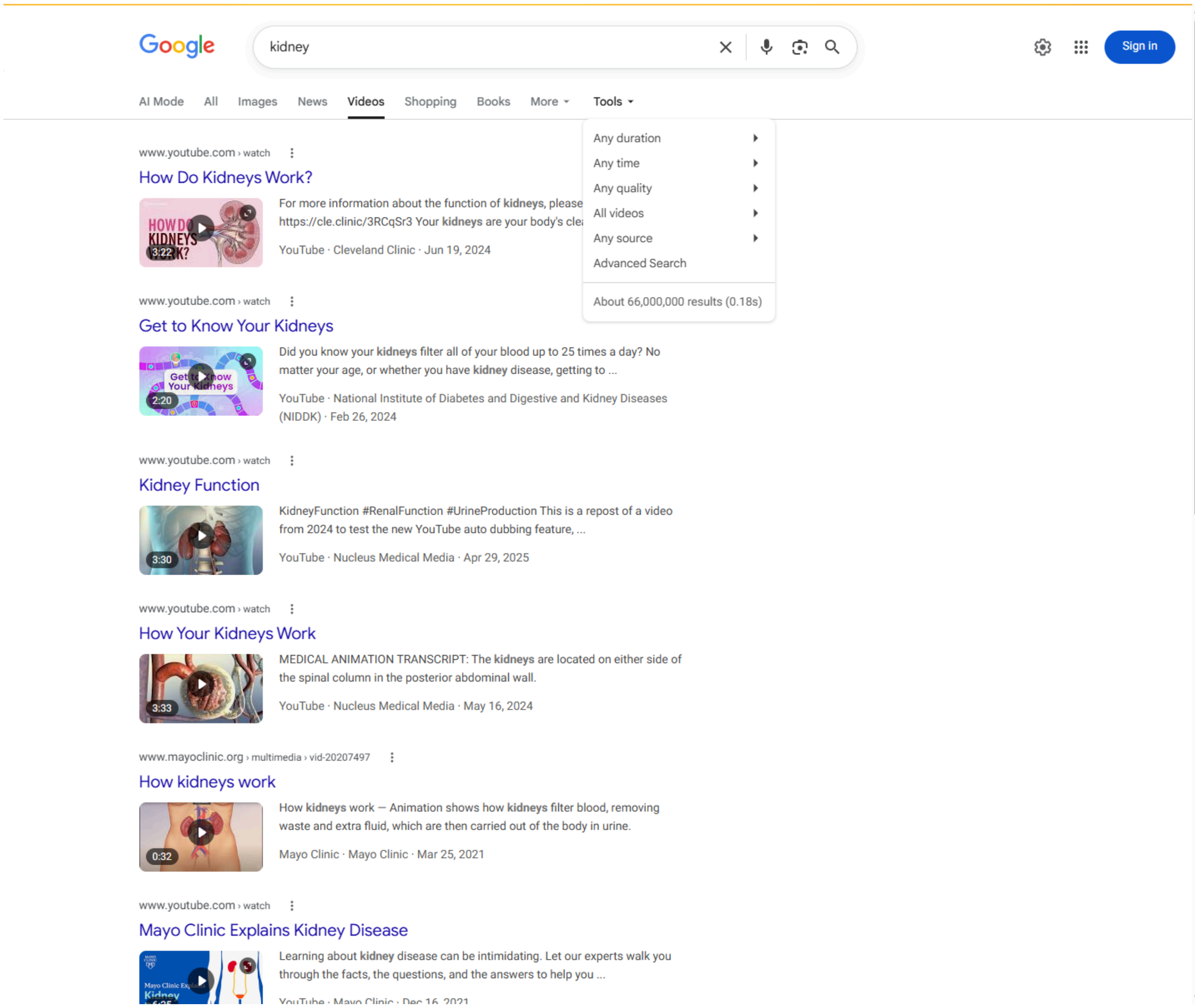
Google Search

Captured 2026-05-13. The result page reports about 211,000,000 results. Reproducible query: https://www.google.com/search?q=kidney&hl=en&num=10&pws=0



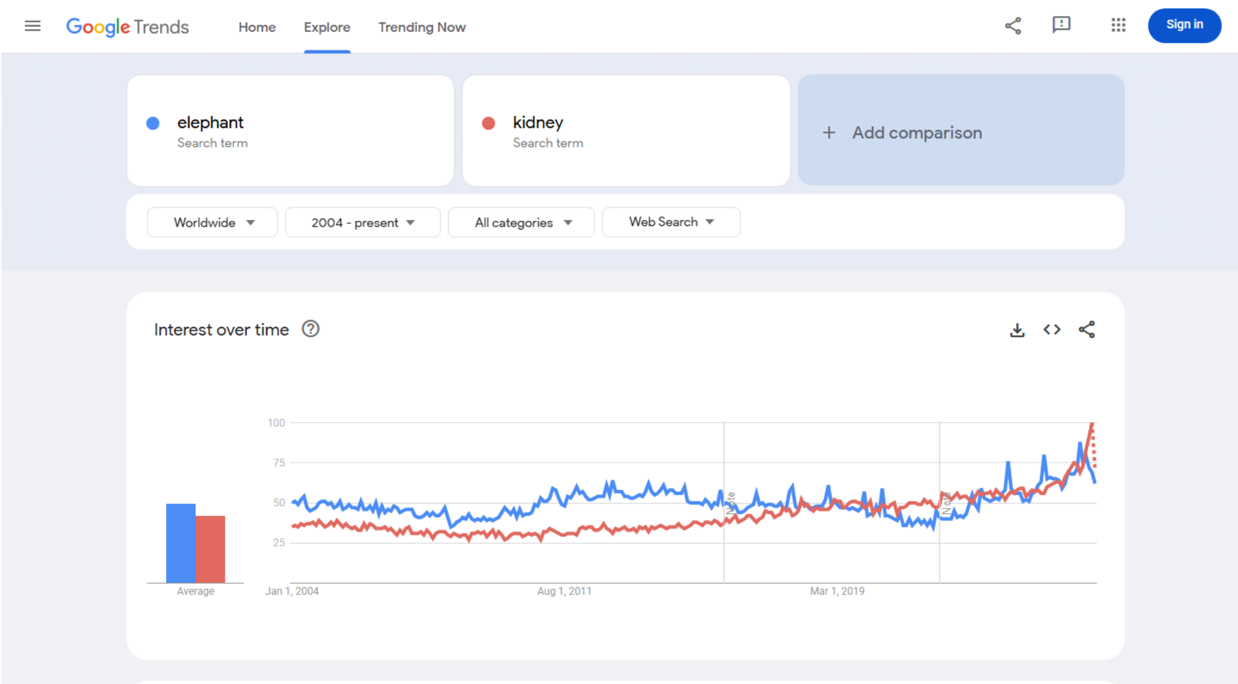
Google Video Search

Captured 2026-05-13. The result page reports about 66,000,000 results. Reproducible query: https://www.google.com/search?tbm=vid&q=kidney&hl=en&num=10&pws=0



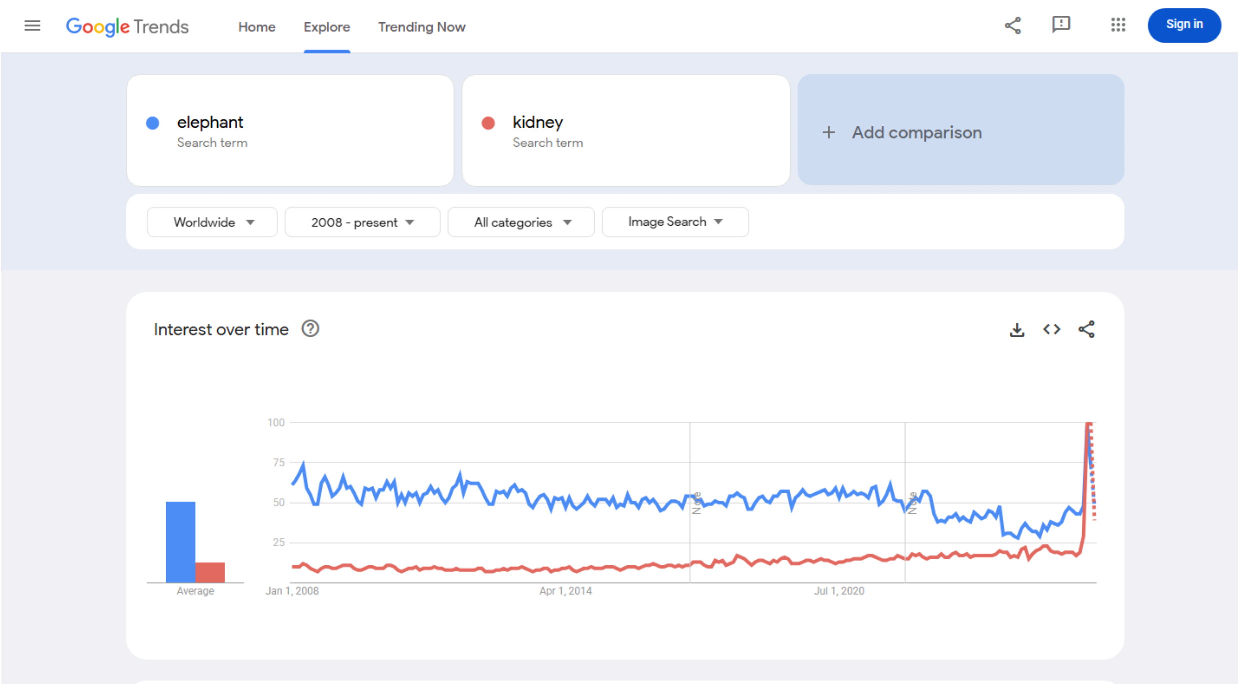
Google Trends - Web Search

Captured 2026-05-13 using Worldwide and 2004-present. Kidney is of the same order as elephant and reaches comparable or greater recent interest. Reproducible query: https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all&q=elephant,kidney



Google Trends - Image Search

Captured 2026-05-13 using Worldwide and 2008-present. The graph shows sustained kidney image-search interest against elephant. Reproducible query: https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all_2008&gprop=images&q=elephant,kidney



Google Books Ngram Viewer

Captured 2026-07-09 using the English corpus, 1500-2022, and smoothing 3. Kidney exceeds elephant in recent published-book usage. Reproducible query: https://books.google.com/ngrams/graph?content=elephant%2Ckidney&year_start=1500&year_end=2022&corpus=en&smoothing=3

F. Completeness

Not applicable. Kidney is independently useful and is not proposed merely to complete a set of organs.

G. Compatibility

Not applicable. This proposal does not rely on a legacy carrier emoji or another encoded pictograph.

Factors for Exclusion

A. Already representable

Kidney is not represented by an existing emoji. Beans cannot identify the organ described in NIDDK's kidney-function overview, and general medical emoji identify care rather than the organ involved in dialysis, transplantation, medication review, or the tests documented by MedlinePlus.

B. Overly specific

Kidney is a primary organ and a broad concept, not a particular disease, procedure, specialty, organization, campaign, or brand. Authoritative public sources use the concept across anatomy, filtration, urine production, testing, dialysis, donation, transplantation, and related care.

C. Open-ended

This proposal does not request a complete anatomy taxonomy. Kidney is supported by its own frequency, multiple meanings, visual distinctiveness, and lack of an adequate substitute. Other organs can be judged independently on the same criteria.

D. Transient

Kidney anatomy and care are durable rather than transient: the embedded Ngram covers 1500-2022; Merriam-Webster's kidney bean entry dates its first known use to 1548; and current NIDDK kidney guidance documents enduring anatomical and care uses.

E. Faulty comparison

The proposal does not argue that kidney should be encoded merely because heart, lungs, or brain exist. Those emoji only demonstrate that anatomical organs can be legible at emoji scale. Kidney's case rests on its own expected usage and expressive gap.

Other Information

The singular name Kidney is concise and searchable even though the example paradigm shows the familiar paired organs. Essential design cues are two asymmetrical maroon kidney forms with inward-facing hila, a visible vertical offset, and short central vessel and ureter cues. Full vascular anatomy and fine detail are intentionally omitted for legibility at 18x18.

Official Unicode proposal guidance:

https://www.unicode.org/emoji/proposals.html